only country to oppose the consensus in favour of India. In fact, the Chinese side conveyed to the Indian delegation at Vienna that it would support the draft decision before the NSG. Contrast this with China's open refusal to support India's application to become a full member of the NSG in 2015, despite the proposal enjoying overwhelming support. China was no longer inhibited in declaring its opposition, even if it had to stand alone.

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The third phase dates from 2009 and extends up to the present, including the aftermath of the Covid-19 pandemic which erupted across the world in late 2019.

The persistence of the economic crisis in the US and the West, the election of Trump as US President in 2016 and, finally, US inability to deal with the public health crisis spawned by the pandemic, reinforced Chinese assessment that the US under Trump had become a dysfunctional country – still dangerous, but already in terminal decline. The events of 6 January 2020, when armed right-wing pro-Trump supporters invaded Capitol Hill in Washington, only reinforced the sense in China that the US decline was probably irreversible. But it would be instructive to track how this change in perception took hold and brought important changes in China's posture towards Asia and the world. This phase may be characterized as one aimed at adjusting existing global regimes and arrangements to reflect China's increased power and influence, but also, where necessary, to set up parallel institutions led by China such as the SCO, the BRI and the Asia Infrastructure Investment Bank (AIIB).

China's foreign policy discourse also began to change. In 2012, at the Eighteenth Party Congress, President Hu Jintao used the term 'Community of Common Destiny' to convey a new type of a more equitable and balanced global development partnership. He said:

> In promoting mutually beneficial cooperation, we should raise awareness about human beings sharing a community of common destiny. [4]

Hitherto, the phrase had been used in the more limited context of China–Taiwan relations. It was now being used to suggest that China was adding a